

# Games Industry Trends

Confidential planning brief | Generated for Strategy Task Force review

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Source: IDG Research Partner Group

Sample: 38 publishers, 214 launches

Scope: Premium and live-service PC/console

## Market Direction

The industry is moving away from a simple premium-versus-live-service split. The strongest performers increasingly combine clear upfront value with a credible long tail: modding, creator challenges, expansions, social systems, seasonal events, ranked mastery, or build-sharing communities. This creates pressure on studios to design launch products as durable ecosystems without adopting the most disliked live-service monetization patterns.

Self-expression and cozy systems remain major growth areas, but they are not the only trend. Survival crafting, RPG sandboxes, sports management, tactical strategy, and extraction-style multiplayer are also showing durable engagement when their systems generate player stories. Competitive racing and traditional sports remain commercially viable but show lower organic cultural spread unless connected to esports, creator challenges, licensed talent, or unusually strong authenticity.

## Key Industry Trends

- **Self-expression as retention:** Character tools, room building, vehicle styling, neighborhood design, team identity, and avatar fashion are functioning as retention systems rather than cosmetic side features.
- **Live-service fatigue:** Players are increasingly hostile to aggressive battle passes, confusing currencies, and launch products that feel designed around storefronts. Transparent DLC, generous base content, and mod support are receiving stronger trust signals.
- **Creator loops:** Streamers and short-form creators prefer games that allow high community interaction: custom builds, challenge routes, emergent failures, fashion reveals, tactical choices, and personal stories.
- **Genre hybridization:** Publishers are blending sports, RPG progression, social hubs, management systems, and sandbox tools. Hybrid projects can expand audience reach, but they fail quickly when the player fantasy is unclear.

Momentum Index by Genre Cluster

| Genre Cluster            | Momentum     | Primary Driver                                    | Main Risk                                            |
|--------------------------|--------------|---------------------------------------------------|------------------------------------------------------|
| Life / cozy simulation   | Very high    | Customization, decorating, community storytelling | Players punish instability and shallow systems       |
| Survival crafting        | High         | Co-op creativity and emergent progression         | Market crowding and content cadence expectations     |
| Action sports / movement | High         | Clip culture, identity, mastery, style            | Audience size must be expanded beyond franchise fans |
| RPG / adventure          | High         | Character attachment and long playtime            | Production cost and narrative scope                  |
| Racing / driving         | Stable       | Handling authenticity and known brands            | Launch spike dependence and limited lifestyle reach  |
| Strategy / management    | Stable niche | Depth, replayability, expert community            | Lower mass-market visibility                         |

Audience Quotes

*"I want games where I can make something that is mine, not just unlock what everyone else gets."*

UK player, 22

*"Battle passes make me feel late before I even start. I prefer expansions I can understand."*

US player, 29

*"The games I watch most are the ones where every creator's playthrough looks different."*

EU viewer, 20

*"Hybrid games are exciting, but I need to understand what I actually do minute to minute."*

UK player, 34